“How was school today?” Léa asked.

Paulette handed her a piece of paper. “I got ten out of ten on my *dictée*.”

“Bravo! We must celebrate.”

Virginie lifted her chin in the direction of Paulette. “What do you say?”

“*Merci*, Tante Léa for helping me.”

Léa felt a swell of emotion in her chest. No one had ever called her Tante before. “Come here, I want a hug.” Paulette leaped into her lap and wrapped her arms around her neck.

“There’s something else Paulette has to tell you,” Rose said. “We’ve been talking about games.”

“A game with the rail carts,” Paulette said, turning to Rose and smiling.

“Go on.”

“Papa and I used to play *cache-cache* with them.” She twirled a finger in the air. “Papa said I was the same size as his crates of wine. He’d attach all the carts together.” She leaped off Léa’s lap. “I’d hide in one, like this.” She crouched low, grinning. “He couldn’t find me!”

Virginie glanced at Léa, then came forward, kneeling at her daughter’s side. “Paulette, tell us where those rail carts are now.”

“He hid them.”

“Where, *chérie*?” Léa could hear the urgency in Virginie’s voice.

“Behind the greenhouse!”

“You mean under the tarp?”

“Yes. Shall I show you?”

“Oh yes,” Virginie said, kissing her on the forehead. “Such a clever girl.”

The evenings were shorter now, and as they made their way across the gravel path, past the vegetable garden, darkness fell fast. Léa looked through the greenhouse’s glass windows, walnuts spread across the floor as far as the eye could see. Now, Édouard’s mention of the walnuts made sense. She brushed past the weeds and purple and white cyclamen growing along the edge of the greenhouse as they advanced to the rear.

“There it is!” Paulette said, indicating a tarp covered with leaves and branches. “Papa keeps a lot of things back here.” She stepped back. “Watch out because spiders make their webs under the tarp.”

Léa pulled one stick and another out of the ground, and with Rose’s help, yanked the tarp off. The sisters gasped at the carts stacked upside